



OUR EARLIER COVERS ON MODI (L-R)

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expressing their opinions freely. NGOs face a hostile environment. Since all the exit pollsters were wrong in one direction, I suspect they got their predictions messed up because people did not tell them the truth about who they were voting for out of fear and said 'yes' to the ruling dispensation. A free press is essential for a vibrant, functioning democracy. If the press is closely monitored and 'guided' to cover countless government events and criticism is muted in fear of retribution, then we all get far removed from ground reality. This is true of other ruling parties too. Perhaps the past regime would not have faced this electoral fate if it hadn't lived in its echo chambers. The autonomy of institutions has been undermined. Enforcement agencies are being used as instruments of terror. Loosely drafted, draconian laws like PMLA and sedition are being used casually. With countless rules and regulations, cases can be filed without much substance. It is well known that, in India, the process is the punishment, and very few cases are ever closed. This is not new, but has been accelerated and adopted as routine practice.

There is much drumbeating about becoming the third-largest economy in the world, little realising that it's primarily a factor of the size of our population. We still rank a lowly 125th in the world in terms of per capita income (PPP). There is gross inequality. The top 1 per cent hold more national wealth now. The top 10 per cent hold nearly 80 per cent. All these are signs of not a very healthy society.

Notwithstanding all this, the BJP has been given another chance to govern India. It has to be congratulated for having fought 10 years of anti-incumbency. It is highly creditable that Modi has piloted the BJP to three consecutive terms, a feat last achieved by Jawaharlal Nehru six decades ago. But the message from the electorate to the party is admonitory, if still indulgent: cut down on the grandstanding, because symbolism does not equal substance, and focus instead on things that really matter to human lives and livelihoods.

The BJP has registered significant successes—most strikingly, a rise in new territories. But its long-term dream to supplant regional parties and turn India into a unitary, two-party system has come up against a sobering reality check. Ironically, what saved the day for the BJP was its phalanx of NDA partners, whom pollsters had predicted would be its weakest link. The message from the electorate applies equally to the Congress, which ran a spirited campaign under Rahul Gandhi, who hit the country trails like a man possessed of revolutionary zeal despite the monetary constraints put his way. The result is the almost doubling of its seats that run pan-India, from Kerala to Punjab to the Northeast. But if it starts fantasising about a return to its glory days, that would be hubris. It has only become a handy instrument for the expression of mass disenchantment. If the party has to progress, it must develop a narrative beyond criticising Modi and the BJP. A vision which takes India forward, not backwards, as many of its hare-brained schemes would suggest.

We will now have an NDA government that is substantively different from the past decade. Modi 3.0 will be different, as he has to rely on two crutches—both known to be wobbly. By now, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar's biggest calling card is that he can dump an alliance faster than you can pronounce its full form. We also have the surprise resurrection of Chandrababu Naidu, another hard bargainer who will now extract major concessions from his new partner. Both Nitish and Naidu are sure to take their Shylockian pound of flesh.

I believe India needs a person like Modi, who has a clear vision for a modern India, is hard-working, gets things done and is incorruptible. Still, with its immense diversity, he must realise that India itself is a coalition. And coalitions can only be ruled by discussion, debate and consensus. It may be slower and more arduous, but it will be more stable and lasting. India is a country with enormous potential. The previous Modi leadership made the world and India realise this, but a different path and style are needed to take us to the bright future that awaits us.

I salute the Indian voter for the 2024 mandate.

(Aroon Purie)